frontiers in Communication

TYPE Review
PUBLISHED 07 September 2026
DOI 10.3389/fcomm.2026.1863261

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OPEN ACCESS

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Hilarius Bambang Winarko,
University of Bunda Mulia, Indonesia

*CORRESPONDENCE
Priya Upreti
priya.phdsom@doonuniversity.ac.in

RECEIVED 23 April 2026
REVISED 01 August 2026
ACCEPTED 03 August 2026
PUBLISHED 07 September 2026

CITATION
Upreti P and Bisht S (2026) Influencing young minds: a hybrid review and research agenda on influencer marketing and young consumer behaviour. Front. Commun. 11:1863261. doi: 10.3389/fcomm.2026.1863261

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Influencing young minds: a hybrid review and research agenda on influencer marketing and young consumer behaviour

Priya Upreti* and Swati Bisht

School of Management, Doon University, Dehradun, India

Purpose: Generation Z cohort is often more susceptible to social media influencers, as they are more involved with and engaged in social media compared to other cohorts. This paper explores the effect of social media influencer marketing on young consumers and how it shapes their decision-making and purchase behaviour.
Design/methodology/approach: The paper used SPAR-4 and the TCCM framework to systematically synthesise the literature from 60 studies focused on young consumer behaviour and influencer marketing. The study aims to identify influencer attributes that shape young consumers' trust, brand perception, brand attitude, brand image, and overall purchase behaviour, including their purchase intent and actual purchase decisions.
Findings: It offers a comprehensive understanding of the elements that impact youth trust, purchase behaviour and psychological barriers surrounding the influencer marketing phenomenon.
Research limitations/implications: While the study adopts a multi-disciplinary approach to review the existing literature and systematically synthesise and summarise the findings, the articles were retrieved from a selected database, and any study falling beyond those search criteria was excluded.
Social implications: This paper draws attention to the role of social media influencer marketing on the holistic well-being of young adults.
Practical Implications: The study provides meaningful guidance for brand marketers on effectively selecting influencers and formulating marketing strategies for younger audiences.
Originality: The paper proposes future propositions and a nomological framework to further inform research in this direction. This study elaborates on the current body of literature, helping brand marketers develop and adopt influencer-led strategies, particularly for younger audiences.

KEYWORDS
consumer behaviour, Gen Z, influencer marketing, social media influencers, SPAR-4 SLR, TCCM, youth

1 Introduction

Social media has transformed the digital landscape through UGC (user-generated content), likes, comments, and shares, making it an interactive medium for communication and engagement (Alves et al., 2016). Social Media platforms have become the primary arenas for brand communication, product awareness, discovery and identity creation. The social media influencers thus act as mediators, narrowing

the gap between brands and consumers and profoundly shaping their trust and buying behaviour (Leung et al., 2022; Vrontis et al., 2021). Djafarova and Foots (2022) describe Generation Z as "digital natives" born between 1995 and 2010 who rely heavily on information from digital creators in their purchasing decisions. This generation is characterised by a profound dependency on social media for identity construction and decision-making, coupled with an innate "persuasion knowledge" that makes them highly resistant to traditional, top-down advertising (Friestad and Wright, 1994). For Gen Z, consumer behaviour is no longer a direct path from awareness to purchase; it is a complex, socially mediated process shaped by the influencers they follow. Research indicates that Gen Z consumers view influencer endorsements not as commercial intrusions but as peer-led advice, provided the influencer maintains a high degree of perceived fit and authenticity (Belanche et al., 2021; Schouten et al., 2020).

Due to high perceived similarity and trustworthiness, younger generations are more likely to associate with social media influencers than with traditional figures (De Veirman et al., 2017; Jin et al., 2019). They admire influencers who demonstrate transparency, especially in disclosing sponsored content, and who align with their ethical and social values (Han and Balabanis, 2024). Conversely, trust is rapidly eroded by "over-commercialisation", deceptive claims or a product-influencer "mis-fit" (Kim and Kim, 2021; Weismueller et al., 2020). De Veirman et al.'s (2017) study emphasised that the popularity of influencers with huge follower counts alone does not influence consumer behaviour. Other significant factors in influencer campaigns, such as credibility, authenticity, parasocial relationships, and sustainability, draw consumer attention and influence purchase decisions (Jin et al., 2019; Kumar and Jibril, 2025).

Platforms like Instagram and TikTok help influencers reach younger audiences more rapidly, fostering trust and authenticity through constant engagement, encouraging them to try trending products, and swaying impulsive buying (Soni and Bhukya, 2025; Vrontis et al., 2021). On the contrary, lack of authenticity, genuineness, and non-disclosure lowers their trust and leads to scepticism and diminished brand loyalty (De Veirman et al., 2017; Kumar and Jibril, 2025).

By synthesising evidence from Scopus-indexed journals, this study aims to classify the underlying mechanisms of influence and highlight critical gaps in current theories. For brand marketers, it offers deep insights underscoring a shift from "reach-based" metrics to "resonance-based" strategies. This research examines the role of SMI-driven marketing in the purchase behaviour of young consumers (i.e., Generation Z) to achieve positive marketing outcomes for this cohort. Based on this, the following research questions have been developed:

RQ1: What are the publication characteristics, content structure and implications of SMI marketing on the purchase behaviour of young consumers?

RQ2: How is our understanding of consumer behaviour with regard to the Gen Z population and influencer marketing advancing within the academic arena?

RQ3: What are the prospective research avenues for exploring the interplay between influencer marketing and young consumers in the future?

Attempts have been made in the past to synthesise literature concerning Generation Z and influencer marketing (Table 1). Ridwan et al. (2025) explore the decision-making behaviour of Gen Z in online buying. It highlighted the collective role of social media, user-generated content (UGC), peer influence, sustainable practices, and reliance on social proof, emotional and moral factors, interactive marketing strategies, and personalization in the decision-making choices of the younger generation. The study used the PRISMA framework to identify relevant articles, and 10 were selected for review. Another study by Barrueta-Pinto et al. (2025) also synthesised the literature on social media influencers and young purchasing behaviour, examining the driving factors that encourage youth purchase, the perception of credibility, authenticity, and influencer-brand collaboration. It deployed the PRISMA framework, and 29 articles were included in the study review.

While the existing literature, as exemplified by Ridwan et al. (2025) and Barrueta-Pinto et al. (2025), has made significant strides in understanding the various dimensions of young consumer behaviour involving social media influencers, there remains a visible gap when it comes to examining the overall impact of social media influencer marketing, such as the type of influencers, type of industry, type of platforms, and the influencer's attributes that affect the young consumers' trust and purchase behaviour. Although the cited studies discuss social media influencers (SMIs) and Generation Z (Gen Z) or youth, the number of articles reviewed was very limited, which does not truly reflect the scope of the review. The current review study extends beyond just the review of all the studies; it significantly contributes to the current state of the literature by providing future propositions through careful examination of the findings and research gaps in the documented studies. It

TABLE 1 Previous literature review concerning generation Z and influencer marketing.

Author (year)	Type of Study	Articles under review	Timeline of articles under study	Publisher	Objective
Ridwan et al. (2025)	SLR	10	2015–2025	Multidisciplinary Reviews	To outline the key factors influencing Gen Z's decision-making process in online purchase behaviour
Barrueta-Pinto et al. (2025)	SLR	29	2018–2023	Red fame	To analyse how social media affects the young generation's purchase behaviour

also provides an extensive nomological framework to aid researchers in deep diving into influencer marketing. All of these reasons were substantial for conducting the systematic literature review on the role of influencer marketing on young consumer behaviour.

2 Methodology used

Another justification for conducting a systematic literature review is that it provides the state of the art through comprehensive mapping and offers a clear perspective for future research to advance knowledge (Paul et al., 2021). It helps synthesise fragmented literature to advance research and develop theory. The study adopted the Scientific Procedures and Rationales for a Systematic Literature Review (SPAR-4-SLR) protocol, rather than the PRISMA framework used in previous reviews, because PRISMA provides little rationale for review decisions (Paul et al., 2021). In this study, 60 articles were included in the final analysis, which is considered sufficient for the review, as it exceeds the threshold of 40 articles suggested by Paul and Criado (2020). To synthesise the findings, the TCCM framework by Paul and Rosado-Serrano (2019) was deployed for its ability to deliver the highest level of clarity and coverage to the review (Paul et al., 2021).

2.1 Development of search string

To develop the search string, the study used the PEO (Population, Exposure, and Outcome) framework to fully capture the scope of the review (refer Table 2).

Based on the above framework, the complete search string used for the final search is below.

Search String- ((“Social Media Influencers”) OR (“SMIs”) OR (“Digital Influencers”) OR (“Influencer Marketing”) AND (“Consumer behaviour”) OR (“Purchase Intention”) OR (“buying behaviour”) OR (“purchase decision”) OR (“consumer decision making”) OR (“consumer trust”) AND (“generation Z”) OR (“Gen Z”) OR (“Young adults”) OR (“Youth”))

TABLE 2 Demonstrates the focus area and terms/keywords used in the database search for each of the PEO segment.

PEO framework	Focus area	Subject terms used in the database searches
Population	Generation Z with access to social media	“Generation Z” OR “Gen Z” OR “young adults” OR “youth”
Exposure	Influencer marketing	“Social Media Influencers” OR “SMIs” OR “Digital Influencers” OR “Influencer Marketing”
Outcome	consumer behaviour	“Consumer behaviour” OR “purchase Intention” OR “buying behaviour” OR “purchase decision” OR “consumer decision-making” OR “consumer Trust”

2.2 Identification of studies

2.2.1 Assembling

This stage involves identifying and acquiring articles from the database. The decisions regarding identification were based on the research domain, research objectives, and source quality and type. The database used in the review study was Scopus, as it is considered the most popular and relevant database for SLR. The main component of acquisition is the search string of the keywords. In our review, the keyword search string was examined using the PEO framework to acquire the articles and achieve the desired results. It also includes the search timeline, which in this case was from 2019 to 2026 (Jan), since the first article was produced in 2019 for that particular search string. In this stage, all documents published between 2019 and 2026 (Jan) were included, and 87 articles were initially reported. The first screening was conducted based on the subject criteria, resulting in 73 documents being identified. The subject areas that were included during the filtering were a) business, management, and accounting; b) social sciences; c) economics, econometrics, and finance; d) arts and humanities; e) multidisciplinary; f) psychology; and g) decision sciences, as these subjects fully cover the scope of the review study.

2.2.2 Arranging

The arranging stage includes the organisation and purification of documents from the first stage. Next, the de-duplication protocol was implemented through automated de-duplication in Zotero, as well as manual audit, to prevent false-positive exclusion through software. The next step includes the study’s inclusion and exclusion criteria. In our study, we included peer-reviewed publications and review papers. Only articles written in English were included, which served as another inclusion criterion. To ensure study quality, we excluded publications in other languages, conference proceedings, and book chapters. Therefore, of the 73 documents in the first stage, after filtering by document type, 64 were articles, of which 61 were articles and 3 were review papers. One article was excluded due to language, as only English-language articles were included in the study, leaving 63 for further analysis.

2.2.3 Assessing

The documents were further evaluated based on title, abstract, and full content screening. Three studies were excluded at this stage as they did not align with the scope of the study, thus making a final study count of 60. To minimise methodological bias for the heterogeneous study designs, a QQM checklist (Quantitative, Qualitative and Mixed-method) was applied. All 60 studies underwent a quality check under 8 indicators, which are: setting, recruitment, administration,

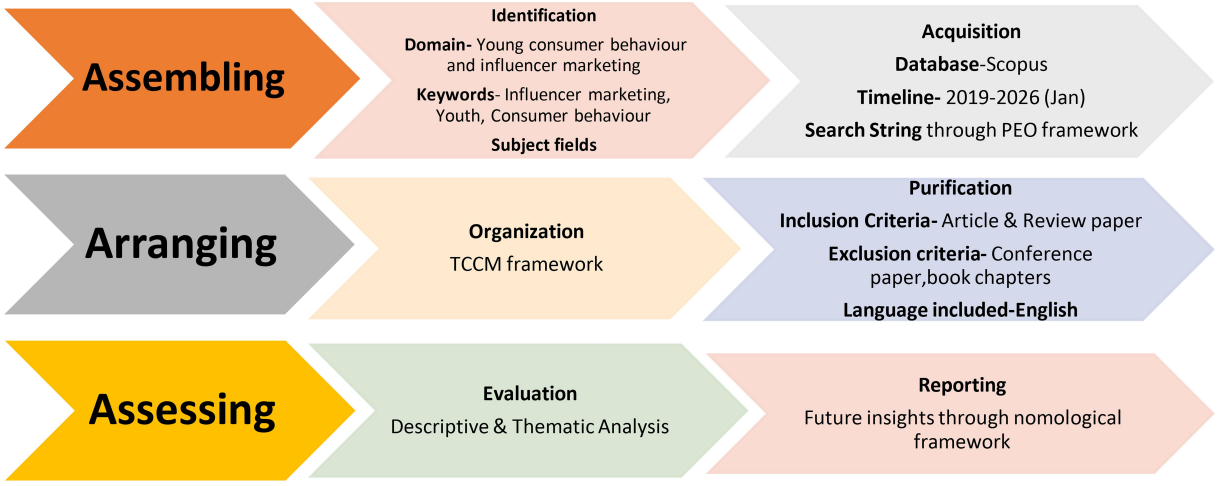


FIGURE 1
SPAR-4 SLR process.

consent, ethics, sample, achieved sample and sample size. Articles were scored according to the QQM three-tiered scoring scheme, which was further converted into percentiles. Articles that had more than 75% were considered "High Quality" ($n = 60$), articles between 50%–74% were considered "Moderate Quality" ($n = 0$) and articles below 50% were considered "Poor Quality" ($n = 0$). The complete list of studies with their QQM scores is provided in Supplementary Appendix A. The 60 final articles underwent descriptive analysis and the TCCM approach in the final assessment step. The review analysis, as well as descriptive analyses, is carried out as part of the review process to attain objectivity. Finally, the study's findings, conclusions, implications and future research avenues were determined. Figure 1 explains the SPAR-4 SLR stages in detail.

2.2.4 Data coding

After the documents were extracted from the database, the complete documents were carefully read, and the data coding procedure was deployed to systematically conduct the review process under the TCCM framework, enabling transparency and reproducibility (Vrontis et al., 2021). Each document was coded for 1) authors 2) countries 3) platform 4) industry type 5) year 6) variables studied 7) research framework (methodology, data collection, sampling technique, and statistical methods) 8) underpinning theories 9) journals 10) conclusion 11) gaps and future research directions. Figure 2 shows the entire data selection process through a systematic flowchart.

3 Finding and analysis

The articles extracted from the SPAR-4 process were then categorised and examined using the TCCM framework by Paul and Rosado-Serrano (2019) to address the study's first research question (RQ1).

3.1 Publication trends

Figure 3 shows the yearly developments in studies concerned with IM and young consumer behaviour, from 2019, when the Gen Z cohort was studied as a separate demographic, to January 2026. The growing trajectory suggests that the surge is not merely because of the platform's popularity, but because of the intersection between young consumers' identity and purchase behaviour, reflecting a fundamental transformation.

Table 3 depicts the top 10 article sources, along with the number of articles and the publishers, from the Scopus database. The increasing number of articles in multidisciplinary journals like PLOS ONE and ACTA PSYCHOLOGICA suggests that traditional digital marketing relied on reach-based metrics, but the paradigm has now shifted to resonance-based metrics. Influencer marketing has now evolved from a mere tactical novelty to a global business research domain. The study area has a footprint in all the major fields, such as marketing, psychology, business, communication, and sustainable consumption.

Figure 4 shows the density visualisation of the keywords in VosViewer based on the 60 articles included in the study. The clustering of keywords like "*social media influencer*", "*consumer behaviour*", "*structural equation modelling*", and "*purchase intention*" reinforces the academic shift from exploratory, qualitative research paradigms to highly rigorous, variance-based causal modelling. This structural clustering maps closely to highly cited conceptual paradigms, showing the digital media endorsers act as primary modern vectors for values, norms, and social expectations, transforming the traditional paths of youth socialisation.

3.2 TCCM framework

Theories, Context, Characteristics, and Methodology were the four parts of the review that addressed the study's second research

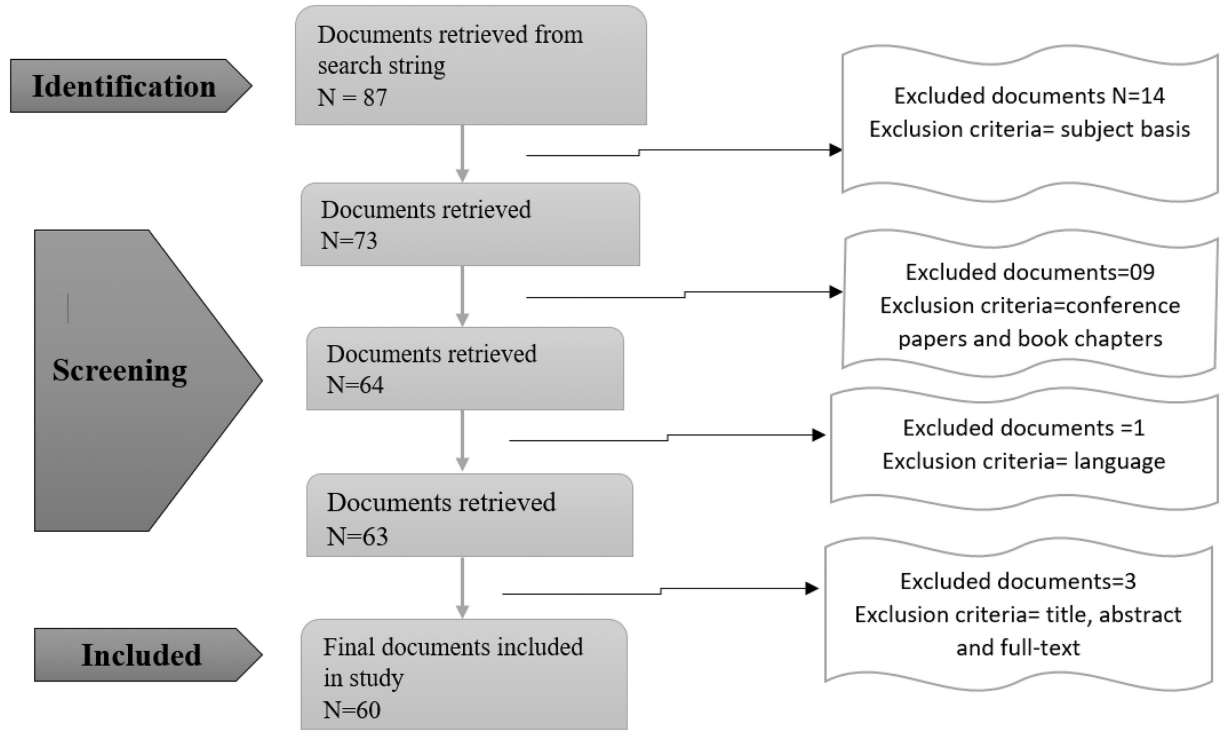


FIGURE 2
Data extraction process.

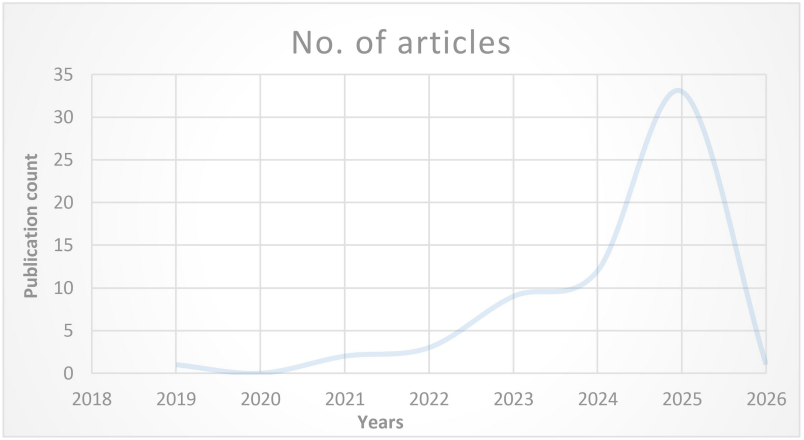


FIGURE 3
Publication trend over the years.

question (RQ2), demonstrating the study's advancement in the academic sphere.

The first part, "Theories", summarises the underlying and foundational concepts of the studies included in the review. The second part is titled "Context", and it assesses the nations, type of industry, platform, and influencers studied in previous documents. The third part is titled "Characteristics", and it observes different variables being researched. The fourth and final part is "Methodology", which explains the research methods and statistical measures being adopted.

3.2.1 Theories

All the theories identified in the literature review are categorically divided into six broad theoretical fields (as shown in Table 4). The most dominant theories primarily belonged to Communication and Persuasion theories, followed by Social, psychological and behavioural theories. Ohanian's Source Credibility theory ($n = 13$) and Parasocial interaction theory ($n = 5$) point towards a general consensus that Gen Zs give utmost importance to endorsers' credibility, like trustworthiness,

expertise and physical attractiveness and perceived relational proximity before planning a purchase (Sitorus et al., 2024; Lawrence and Meivitawanli, 2023; Vilas Chavare et al., 2024) formed through two-way interaction.

Furthermore, the Stimulus-Organism-Response theory ($n = 9$) sets a theoretical basis for most literature articles, suggesting that the content of the digital creators acts as external stimuli (S) that alter the emotional and cognitive states (O), which leads to purchase behaviour (R) (Orelskaia et al., 2025; Renganathan et al., 2025; Zhou and Baskaran, 2025). For instance, the study by Kant et al. (2025) suggests that brand perception is driven mainly by attractiveness and both brand perception and influencer attitudes directly influence purchase intentions. However, the study also shows that perceived credibility has no impact on attitude towards the influencer with respect to the fashion industry. The Theory of Planned Behaviour by Ajzen (1991) and the Elaboration Likelihood Model also prevail predominantly in the literature, indicating the role of social media in strategically shaping the consumption patterns of the young population (Azhar et al., 2025; Pham et al., 2026; Wang et al., 2025a).

TABLE 3 Lists the top sources and their publishers included in the study, sourced from the scopus database.

Sources	Publisher	Articles
PLoS One	Public Library of Science	5
Young consumers	Emerald	4
Acta psychologica	Elsevier	3
F1000research	F1000 Research Ltd	2
Innovative marketing	LLC CPC	2
Journal of global scholars of marketing science: bridging Asia and the world	Taylor and Francis Ltd.	2
Journal of theoretical and applied electronic commerce research	MDPI	2
Search journal of media and communication research	Taylor's University Lakeside Campus	2
Studies in media and communication	Redfame Publishing Inc.	2
Sustainability (Switzerland)	MDPI	2

3.2.2 Context

3.2.2.1 Countries studied

Figure 5 shows the country-level production of articles included in the review. The bar chart shows that India, China, and the United States are the top three countries producing the most articles on the relationship between Gen Z and social media influencer marketing. The graph also shows that production is generally high where the Gen Z population is most dominant in their digital consumption patterns. One study drew its sample from two countries; in all studies, the data were restricted to a single country, limiting the generalizability of findings

3.2.2.2 Industries studied

Figure 6 shows the distribution of articles by industry type. The majority of the documents were focused on the fashion industry, followed by the beauty and cosmetic industry. This may be because Gen Z follows fashion and beauty influencers more closely and often relies on their recommendations when making purchase decisions (Azhar et al., 2025; Pham et al., 2026; Vinish et al., 2025; Wang et al., 2025a). However, as social media marketing expands, and with vast content marketed by

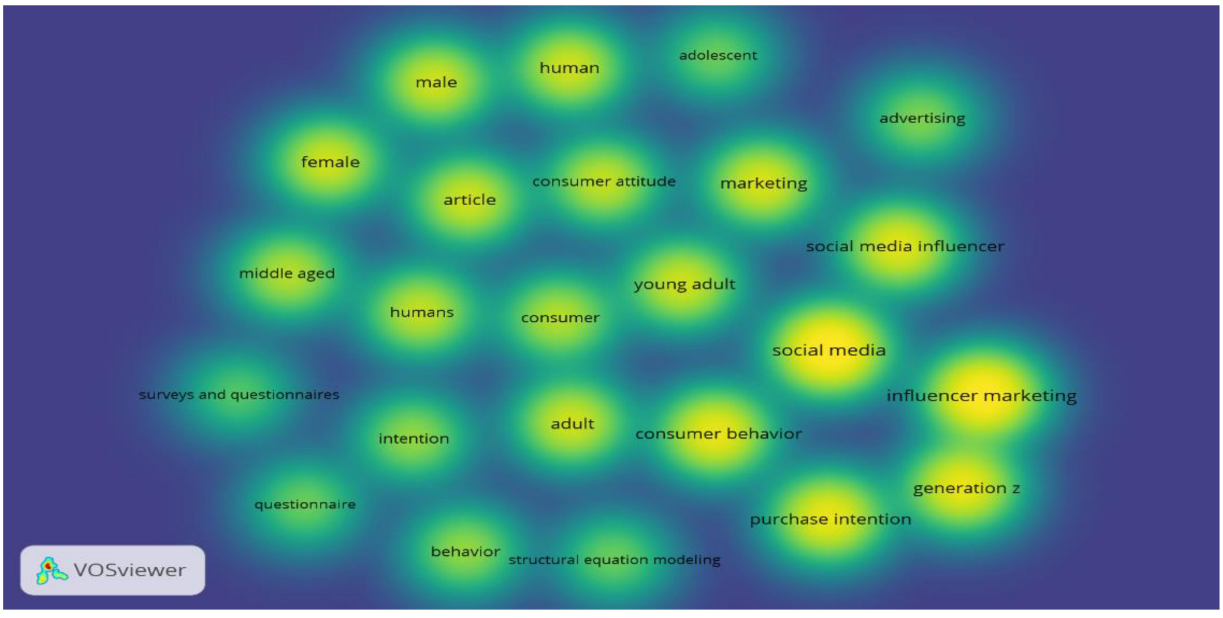


FIGURE 4
Density visualisation of keywords through vos viewer.

TABLE 4 List of theories identified.

Primary subject field	Theories	Occurrence
Marketing, Advertising and Consumer Behaviour	Consumer Decision- Making Model	2
	Theory of Consumption Values	1
	Ad Value Model	1
	Value-Attitude-Behaviour Theory	1
	Tri-component Attitude Model	1
	Customer Socialization	1
	Consumer Trust Theory	1
	Perceived Risk Theory	1
	Signaling Theory	5
	Match-up Hypothesis	2
Communication and Persuasion Theories	Source Credibility Theory	13
	Elaboration Likelihood Model (ELM)	5
	Persuasion Theory	4
	Parasocial Interaction	6
	Narrative Transportation Theory	1
	Media Richness Theory	1
	Social Presence Theory	1
	Source-Message-Channel Paradigm	1
	Meaning Transfer Model	2
	TEARS Model (Trustworthiness, Expertise, Attractiveness, Respect, Similarity)	2
	Source Attractiveness Theory	1
	Heuristic Systematic Model	1
Social Psychology & Behavioural Theories	Theory of Planned Behaviour (TPB) & Extended TPB	6
	Theory of Reasoned Action (TRA)	2
	Stimulus-Organism-Response (SOR) Theory	9
	Social Comparison Theory	3
	Social Identity Theory	2
	Self-Determination Theory	2
	Attribution Theory	1
	Cognitive Dissonance/Theory of Congruence	3
	Reactance Theory	1
	Theory of Motivated Reasoning	1
	Symbolic Interactionism	1
Social Influence and Relationship Theories	Social Influence Theory	7
	Attachment Theory & Emotional Attachment Theory	1
	Self-Expansion Theory	1
	Social Power Theory	1
	Equity Theory	1
	Social Network Theory	1
Learning and Cognitive Theories	Social Cognitive Theory	2
	Social Learning Theory	2
	Conditioning Theory	1
	Associative Learning Theory	1
	Dual Process Theory	1
	Perception Theory	1
	Selectivity Hypothesis	1
Management and Strategic Framework	Strategic Diffusion Theory	1
	Cost-Benefit Analysis	1
	Engagement Theory	1
	Deterrence Theory	1
	Neutralization Theory	1

human as well as virtual influencers, Gen Zs are engaging with other product choices too from industries such as sports, food and beverage and entertainment (Chen et al., 2025; Jung and Kim, 2025; Yao et al., 2025).

3.2.2.3 Platform studied

The results of our review indicate that Instagram was the most examined platform ($n = 27$). The studies were also conducted on other dominant platforms: TikTok/Douyin ($n = 19$), YouTube ($n = 10$), and Facebook ($n = 9$). Dominance stems from these platforms being most commonly used by influencers to reach young audiences. The other platforms, such as Snapchat, WEIBO, and WeChat, were also mentioned in the studies, but they were studied only alongside the dominant platforms. 17 studies in the review process followed a general approach and did not clearly mention platform names.

3.2.2.4 Type of influencers studied

The majority of studies do not define the specific type of influencer and were based on broader constructs of social media influencers ($n = 31$). Some studies in the review defined the influencer type under study. 4 studies describe their influencer type being studied as Virtual Influencers, 4 studies were done on celebrity influencers, 8 studies were dedicated to micro, macro and mega influencers, out of which 3 studies were comparison-based. 2 studies were there on live streamers and 1 study each on green influencers, kid influencers, Key Opinion

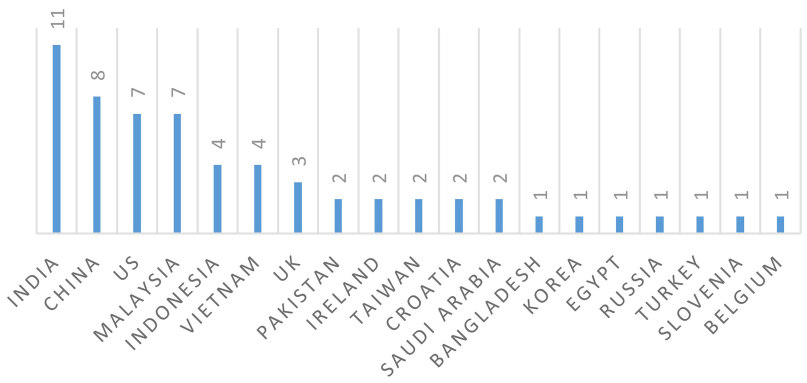


FIGURE 5
Country-wise production of articles.

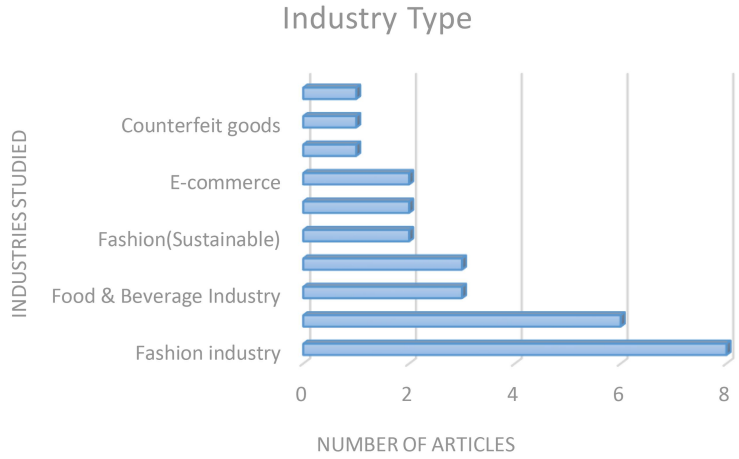


FIGURE 6
Industry-wise distribution of articles.

leaders (KOLs), and Key Opinion Consumers (KOCs). This shows the need for more studies on specific influencer types, especially kid influencers, VIs, KOLs, and KOCs. Lal and Sharma (2021) define the typology of SMIs as Snoopers, Informers, Entertainers, and Infotainers, and examine their impact on different aspects of purchase behaviour among youth, such as conviction, preference, liking, and purchase. Future work should investigate extending this typology into various subtypes, as it is not definitive. Eastin et al. (2025) conducted a study based on Lil Miquela, a virtual influencer, and its impact on MZ consumer behaviour. More scholarly work is required on other VIs, their attributes, and AR-induced influencer content that can affect young consumers.

3.2.3 Characteristics

Table 5 describes the independent variables, or antecedents, categorised into various themes and sub-themes. The broad themes identified for the independent variables are grouped into 6 categories, each further divided into 22 sub-themes. The independent variables or antecedents were then distributed across these sub-themes.

Table 6 lists mediators and moderators categorised into themes and sub-themes. The table also highlights the key citations for each theme from the literature included in the review.

3.2.4 Methodology

3.2.4.1 Sampling technique used

Figure 7 shows the different types of sampling techniques used in the review studies. Most studies used non-probability convenience and purposive sampling, as the target population was Generation Z and young adults who met the criteria for these techniques. Snowball and referral sampling were also used because the studies were

TABLE 5 List of independent variables/antecedents identified in the literature.

Themes	Sub-themes	Independent variables	Key Authors
Influencer-related factors	Source Credibility dimensions & Influencer Characteristics	Expertise, Trustworthiness, Attractiveness (physical and social), Similarity, Homophily, Respect, Popularity, Likability, Familiarity	Wang et al. (2025b), Nguyen and Nguyen (2025), Vinish et al. (2025), Ali et al. (2025), Sitorus et al. (2024), Vilas Chavare et al. (2024), Jung and Kim (2025), Ishomi et al. (2025), Shaheen et al. (2025), Saad et al. (2025), Zhou and Baskaran (2025), Lim and Ng (2025), Renganathan et al. (2025), Wong et al. (2024), Babu et al. (2024), Angmo and Mahajan (2024), Rizomyliotis et al. (2024), Ge (2024), Tian et al. (2023), Lawrence and Meivitawanli (2023), Sharipudin et al. (2023), Satria et al. (2024), Ghaleb and Alawad (2024)
	Influencer types and categories	Micro vs. mega vs. nano influencers, Traditional celebs vs. SMIs, Virtual/AI influencers and specific niches (e.g., Lifestyle vs. brand influencers, health vs. fashion	Wang et al. (2025a, 2025b) Azhar et al., 2025, Chen et al. (2025), Yao et al. (2025), Putra et al. (2025), Orelskaia et al. (2025), Leite et al. (2024), Bratina (2024), Hazari and Sethna (2023), Sun et al. (2022), Sharma et al. (2025)
	Relational Attributes	Wishful identification, PSI, Intimacy, Empathy and Social connectedness	Wang et al. (2025b), Jung and Kim (2025), Tian et al. (2023), Alves (2023), Sun et al. (2022)
	Professional Background	education status, socio-economic status, professionalism	Yao et al. (2025), Zhou and Baskaran (2025)
Content and Platform Factors	Content Characteristics	Content Relevance, Informative value, Entertainment value, Visual Aesthetics, Argument Quality, Materialistic Symbols, and "Vividness".	Bui et al. (2025), Azhar et al., 2025, Nallasivam et al. (2025), Shaheen et al. (2025), Saad et al. (2025), Renganathan et al. (2025), Sinha and Srivastava (2025), Wang et al., 2025a
	Creative elements	Use of music, humor, short-duration formats, and "Growing up narratives".	Eastin et al. (2025),Munsch (2021)
	Disclosure and transparency	Sponsorship disclosure (displayed vs. not displayed), and Authenticity.	Angmo and Mahajan (2024), Sesar et al. (2023), De Keyzer (2023)
	Platform Functionality	Interactivity, Social Presence, Augmented Reality (AR) features, and Social Advocacy.	Wang et al. (2025b), Vinish et al. (2025), Zhou and Baskaran (2025), Babu et al. (2024), Sinha and Srivastava (2025), Sun et al. (2022)
	Content Type	User-Generated Content (UGC), Brand Storytelling, and Product Showcases.	Nallasivam et al. (2025)
Brand and Product Factors	Congruence	Influencer-product fit	Wang et al. (2025b), Lawrence and Meivitawanli (2023)
	Product Attributes	Perceived Value, Price/Affordability, Country of Origin, and Sustainability (e.g., Sustainable vs. Non-sustainable food),	Zhang and Wu (2025), Leite et al. (2024), Ge (2024), De Keyzer (2023), Bui and Pham (2024)
	Brand Perception	Brand Awareness, Trust, Prestige, Uniqueness, and Personalized Recommendations.	Orelskaia et al. (2025), Nallasivam et al. (2025), Orelskaia et al. (2025), Wong et al. (2024)
	Cues	Extrinsic(Packaging), and Intrinsic cues(Product Content)	Ilinajwa and Rusni (2025)
Psychological and Personality Factors	Personality Models	HEXACO (Honesty-Humility, Emotionality, Extraversion, Agreeableness, Conscientiousness, Openness).	Alves de Castro and Sousa (2025)
	Psychological Barriers	The Paradox of Choice, FOMO (Fear of Missing Out), FoBO (Fear of Better Options), and FoDA (Fear of Doing Anything).	Pham et al. (2026)
	Decision-making models	Theory of Planned Behavior (Attitude, Subjective Norms, Perceived Behavioral Control).	Djafarova and Foots (2022)
	Social Influence	Informational vs. Normative Social Influence, Peer Influence, and Family/Friend views.	Yao et al. (2025), Župan et al. (2025), Nallasivam et al. (2025),Ge (2024), Sharipudin et al. (2023), Borja et al. (2025)

(*Continued*)

TABLE 5 Continued

Themes	Sub-themes	Independent variables	Key Authors
	Neuro-marketing metrics	Eye-tracking, facial response, and memory retention levels.	Ishomi et al. (2025)
Behavioural and Engagement Factors	Digital Engagement	Interaction rates (likes, comments, shares), time spent on platform, and responsiveness to ads.	Nallasivam et al. (2025), Cao et al. (2025), Munsch (2021)
	Consumer Response	Purchase Intention, Brand Loyalty, e-WOM (Electronic Word of Mouth) generation, and Consumer Trust.	Pham et al. (2026), Bui et al. (2025), Orelskaia et al. (2025), Ateş et al. (2024), Alves (2023)
	EPIC model	Evaluating effectiveness via Empathy, Persuasion, Impact, and Communication	Lal and Sharma (2021)
	Risk Perceptions	Perception of harmful content (fraudulent, noxious, or addictive) and denial of responsibility.	Alves (2023), Borja et al. (2025)

limited to a particular demographic, i.e., youth and Generation Z. Seven studies compared Gen Z with other cohorts, such as Gen Y and Millennials. Further comparative studies can help marketers formulate strategies for different target segments.

3.2.4.2 Research design

Table 7 indicates the research methodology used in the review documents. The majority of the studies used a quantitative approach, including survey questionnaires administered online and offline. Qualitative studies adopted semi-structured interviews, focus groups, and in-depth interviews. The three studies adopted a mixed-methods approach, using both quantitative and qualitative methodologies.

3.2.4.3 Statistical methods applied

Table 8 describes the statistical methods applied for analysis. Most studies have used Structural Equation Modelling for analysis. 37 studies used SEM; of these, 22 used only SEM, and 15 used it alongside other statistical methods.

4 Future research agenda

The review advances theoretical contributions by synthesising gaps in the existing literature through TCCM dimensions and provides a roadmap for further studies on influencer marketing and generational cohorts. Given the dynamic landscape of social media influencer marketing, the study also provides future propositions with conceptual indicators and proposes a nomological framework to deepen understanding of SMIs and their contribution to achieving marketing outcomes. This provides a meaningful explanation of RQ3 in our review study.

Table 9 addresses gaps in the existing literature and summarises them by offering suggestions for theory development, new contexts, emerging characteristics, and methodologies.

4.1 Future research avenues

Using the TCCM framework, a thematic analysis was conducted to identify future research avenues. The themes thus formed were further translated into a number of propositions that serve as the basis for future studies, as shown in Figure 8.

4.1.1 Ethical and privacy concerns

For Gen Z, trust has been the primary indicator of their engagement with social media influencers. However, trust takes considerable time and effort to build, yet it erodes quickly if not managed properly. Common reasons include non-disclosure, false claims, and unethical practices (Lou and Yuan, 2019; Weismueller et al., 2020). Gen Z, the most vulnerable cohort, considers it an ethical obligation for influencers to deliver authentic, trustworthy content to build long-term brand loyalty (Djafarova and Foots, 2022; Han and Balabanis, 2024). If they fail to do so, it not only lowers their expectations but also leads to a negative relationship with the brands and the SMIs, significantly reducing their credibility and heightening communication anxieties (De Keyzer, 2023; Sesar et al., 2023) (refer Table 10 for conceptual indicators).

Proposition 1 (a) Consumer's data privacy concerns weaken the relationship between perceived trustworthiness of SMIs and young consumers' purchase behaviour.

Proposition 1 (b) Explicit sponsorship disclosure by SMIs increases perceived authenticity of endorsements and reduces deceptive communication anxieties.

Proposition 1 (c) The influencer's social responsibility behaviour and long- term brand loyalty are positively moderated by ethical consumption values in Gen Z consumers.

4.1.2 Emotional and psychological susceptibility concerns

Most studies have identified that young adults are highly susceptible to peer-led advice and psychological triggers. Gen Z relies heavily on social media influencers for identity construction, which may not be the case for other generational cohorts like millennials and Gen X. Both positive and negative emotional and psychological behavioural assimilation have different consequences for their consumption patterns. While positive emotions such as PSI (Parasocial Interaction), intimacy,

TABLE 6 List of mediators and moderators identified in the literature.

Themes	Sub-themes	Mediators and moderators	Authors
Influencer-Related Factors	Credibility and Authenticity	Source Credibility (Trustworthiness, Expertise, Attractiveness), Perceived Authenticity, Perceived Endorsement Authenticity.	Lim and Ng (2025), Chen et al. (2025), Ali et al. (2025), Vilas Chavare et al. (2024), Saad et al. (2025), Cao et al. (2025), Leite et al. (2024), Sesar et al. (2023), De Keyzer (2023), Soni and Bhukya (2025)
	Relational Mediators	Parasocial Interaction (PSI), Wishful Identification, Self-Identification with streamers, Intimacy, and Empathy.	Alves de Castro and Sousa (2025), Babu et al. (2024), Bratina (2024), Lawrence and Meivitawanli (2023), Eastin et al. (2025), Soni and Bhukya (2025)
	Fit &Congruence	Product-Endorser Fit, Self-Congruity, Influencer-Product Congruence, and Perceived Similarity.	Chen et al. (2025), Lim and Ng (2025), Renganathan et al. (2025)
	Inspiration and Aspiration	"Desire to Mimic", "Desire to Emulate" (especially in kids' influencers), and Influencer Inspiration.	Renganathan et al. (2025), Rasmussen et al. (2022), Soni and Bhukya (2025)
Brand and Product Related Factors	Brand Perception	Brand Attitude, Brand Trustworthiness, Brand Equity, Brand Awareness, Brand Consciousness, Brand Perception	Wang et al. (2025b), Ali et al. (2025), Nallasivam et al. (2025), Sesar et al. (2023), Lal and Sharma (2021), Kant et al. (2025), Sharma et al. (2025)
	Perceived Value	Price Value, Social Value, Emotional Value, Quality Value, and E-service Quality	Pham et al. (2026), Wong et al. (2024), Bui and Pham (2024)
	Product Cues	Eco-labelling, Product Type (Sustainable vs. Non-sustainable), and Packaging (Extrinsic cues).	De Keyzer (2023), Panopoulos et al. (2023)
Consumer Individual Differences	Demographic	Age (Gen X, Y, Z, Alpha), Gender, Income levels, Education, and Socio-economic status	Nallasivam et al. (2025), Zhang and Wu (2025), Zhou and Baskaran (2025), Bratina (2024), Borja et al. (2025)
	Personality Traits	User Personality - Introversion vs. Extraversion, and Materialism.	Hazari and Sethna (2023), Rasmussen et al. (2022)
	Behavioural traits	Green Consumption Values, Environmental Concerns, and Subjective Norms, Consumer Knowledge, Individual self-expansion,Attitude,Purchase Intention	Yao et al. (2025), Ali et al. (2025), Sitorus et al. (2024), Vilas Chavare et al. (2024), Orelskaia et al. (2025), Rizomyliotis et al. (2024), Sharma et al. (2025), Bui and Pham (2024)
Psychological and Emotional Factors	Emotional Traits	Affective Attitude (Pleasure, Arousal, Dominance), Nostalgia, Pride, Hope, Emotional Attachment, and Brand Attachment, Emotional Trust, Upward Assimilative Emotion and Contrastive Emotions	Wang et al. (2025a, 2025b), Azhar et al., 2025, Nguyen and Nguyen (2025), Jung and Kim (2025), Zhou and Baskaran (2025)
	Cognitive traits	Perceived Information Credibility, Perceived Usefulness, Information Adoption, and Perceived Risk.	Azhar et al., 2025, Vinish et al. (2025), Bui et al. (2025), Cao et al. (2025), Wang et al., 2025a
	Psychological traits	FOMO (Fear of Missing Out), FOPO (Fear of Other People's Opinion), and Paradox of Choice (FOBO, FODA)	Putra et al. (2025)
	Social traits	Social Satisfaction, Social Image	Yao et al. (2025), Tian et al. (2023), Djafarova and Foots (2022)
Engagement Factors	Involvement	Message Processing Involvement (MPI), Social Media Message Involvement, and Level of Social Media Usage.	Eastin et al. (2025)
	Engagement Metrics	Instagram Engagement (Time spent, interaction), Live Stream Engagement, and User-Generated Content (UGC) creation.	Zhang and Wu (2025), Zhou and Baskaran (2025), Panopoulos et al. (2023)
	Technological Mediators	Sense of tele-presence, Ease of Accepting Unrealism, and AR-induced content (Novelty, Vividness).	Zhang and Wu (2025), Cao et al. (2025), Eastin et al. (2025)

and empathy drive consumer purchases (Azhar et al., 2025; Putra et al., 2025; Wang et al., 2025a), negative emotions such as FOMO (fear of missing out), social anxieties, and the paradox of choice can often lead to compulsive and unplanned consumer behaviour (Alves, 2023; Alves de Castro and Sousa, 2025; Pham et al., 2026; Shaheen et al., 2025) (refer Table 11 for conceptual indicators).

Proposition 2 (a) Negative emotional triggers have a stronger effect on unplanned compulsive buying than positive emotional triggers.

Proposition 2 (b) The high content quality of influencers moderates the effect of psychological barriers like the paradox of choice and FOBO on decision paralysis, thus leading to consumers' willingness to buy.

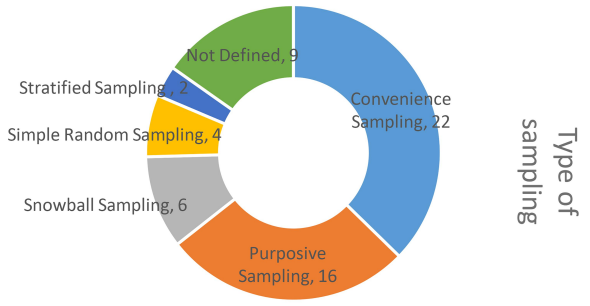


FIGURE 7
Type of sampling technique used.

TABLE 7 Research designs used.

Type of research design	*N*
Quantitative	41
Qualitative	5
Descriptive	4
Mixed-method	3
Experimental	1
Quasi-experimental	1
Explanatory research design	1
Scenario-based	1
Conclusive research design	1
Exploratory research design	1

TABLE 8 Statistical methods used.

Statistical analysis	*N*
SEM	37
Factor Analysis	12
Regression Analysis	9
Thematic Analysis	5
Descriptive Statistical Analysis	5
ANOVA & MANOVA	3
t-test	2
Content Analysis	1
fuzzy set Analysis	1
ANCOVA	1
Machine Learning model	1

4.1.3 Human vs. virtual influencers concerns

Marketers are now moving beyond the concept of human-touch to test the "ease of accepting unrealism". The choice between a human and a virtual influencer also depends on the product-influencer fit and brand congruence (Nallasivam et al., 2025; Orelskaia et al., 2025). The replication of human persona through storytelling, growing-up narratives, and attributes such as credibility and interactivity can boost the self-alignment concept among consumers through highly immersive technologies (Eastin et al., 2025; Sinha and Srivastava, 2025). Although studies have measured the impact of influencers' attributes, both human and virtual. Future studies should carefully examine their comparisons and assess whether young adults exhibit similar consumer behaviour with human and virtual influencers. Also, how do young adults perceive realism in human and virtual influencers? Technological advancement through AR-induced content, VIs' informativeness, narrative styles and entertainment enhance consumers' engagement and purchase intention (Cao et al., 2025; Wang et al., 2025b) (refer Table 12 for conceptual indicators).

Proposition 3 (a) Human influencers exhibit high emotional trust in consumers through genuine parasocial interaction (PSI) while virtual influencers draw high engagement through AR-induced content vividness.

Proposition 3 (b) The type of influencer (human vs. virtual) moderates the relationship between brand anthropomorphism and consumers' purchase intent.

4.1.4 Sustainable marketing concerns

The studies have highlighted that sustainable choices are more prevalent among specific genders, i.e., females, and in specific industries such as fashion, food, FMCG, and self-care, where they successfully drive consumer engagement and purchase intention (De Keyzer, 2023; Ge, 2024; Pham et al., 2026). Sustainable marketing practices, such as eco-labelling, are likely to serve a positive public image, thereby strengthening brand loyalty (Panopoulos et al., 2023). Some studies argue that due to Gen Z's desire to mimic influencer behaviour, it might lead to unsustainable consumption patterns too (Soni and Bhukya, 2025). Therefore, there is a need to further explore different demographics and cultural setups to study the sustainability impact on consumption patterns (refer Table 13 for conceptual indicators).

Proposition 4 Consumer's perceived product value positively affects green consumption intention through sustainable influencer marketing practices.

4.1.5 Crisis management concerns

As we are aware, the digital market is quite volatile and continues to evolve over time; it is crucial to examine how consumer behaviour adapts to the emerging sensitivities of a changing world and what role influencers play in shaping those behaviours. For instance, the pandemic and post-pandemic sustainable shift in fashion consumption (Pham et al., 2026). Similarly, political changes, war crises, medical emergencies, and scandals can affect public trust and opinions (refer Table 14 for conceptual indicators).

Proposition 5 (a) Consumer engagement becomes significantly high towards influencers with high social advocacy in case of macro environmental crises (such as wars, political changes or health emergencies).

Proposition 5 (b) Influencer's credibility declines from negative e-WOM electronic word-of-mouth) that significantly increases consumers' brand detachment.

Figure 9 provides a nomological framework by systematically analysing the existing literature and suggests a list of

TABLE 9 Suggestions related to theories, context, characteristics and methodology.

TCCM Framework	Suggestions for future research
Theories	• Frameworks like the HEXACO framework should be tested in a cultural context • More theories to be tested and advanced, such as Extended TPB, an attribution theory for integrative and cross-disciplinary research. • Using the TEARS model for different generational cohorts and cultural contexts to have a better understanding of consumer behavior. • The SOR theory framework is to be extended to include personality differences and other marketing stimuli across different generational cohorts and platforms.
Context	• Future research should include comparative studies across a more diverse population, platforms, and industries, including virtual and real influencer effects on Gen Z. • Understanding category-specific influencer marketing strategy and emotional response. (E.g. second-hand luxury product categories, electronics, tech products, sports, travel and food and beverages) • Exploring other consumer segments like international travellers, working professionals, families, etc. • Examining specific content such as tutorials, product reviews, blogs, podcasts, connotative and denotative content, followers' knowledge, influencer sizes (micro, macro, and celebrity), and influencer types (KOLs, KOCs and live streamers) and their impact on consumer well-being.
Characteristics	• Future studies to explore how immersive technologies like VI/AR, AI-based-personalisation impact emotional and psychological behavior of consumers, such as credibility, nostalgia and persuasion knowledge. • Additional psychological variables (brand attachment, self-concept alignment, and emotional intensity), unmeasured traits (materialism, brand affinity, brand love, anthropomorphism, brand authenticity, peer influence, visual aesthetic quality, loyalty, competence) and demographic attributes will further explicate the dynamic interplay between SMI attributes, meme marketing, purchase intention, and unplanned purchase behaviour. • Moderators such as consumer media literacy, PSI, product-endorser fit, digital familiarity, follower-influencer similarity, age, nostalgia proneness, interaction quality, socio-economic status, environmental awareness, economic context, cultural differences, and time spent on social media should be evaluated to expand the conceptual model. • Variables like sponsorship disclosure, celebrity-brand congruency, and emotional responses also warrant experimental exploration.
Ethodology	• Longitudinal and experimental study designs, such as video-based methods, eye-tracking, facial emotion recognition, and neuromarketing, will be incorporated in the future. • Use of econometric approaches (instrumental variables, panel data methods), observational methods (e.g., engagement patterns, purchasing habits), Machine learning models (Random Forest/Gradient Boosting), deep learning, and sentiment analysis could complement self-reported perceptions. • Ethnographic and cross-cultural research in Western, Asian, and Middle Eastern markets is suggested to provide valuable insights into cultural nuances and the global relevance of relationships.

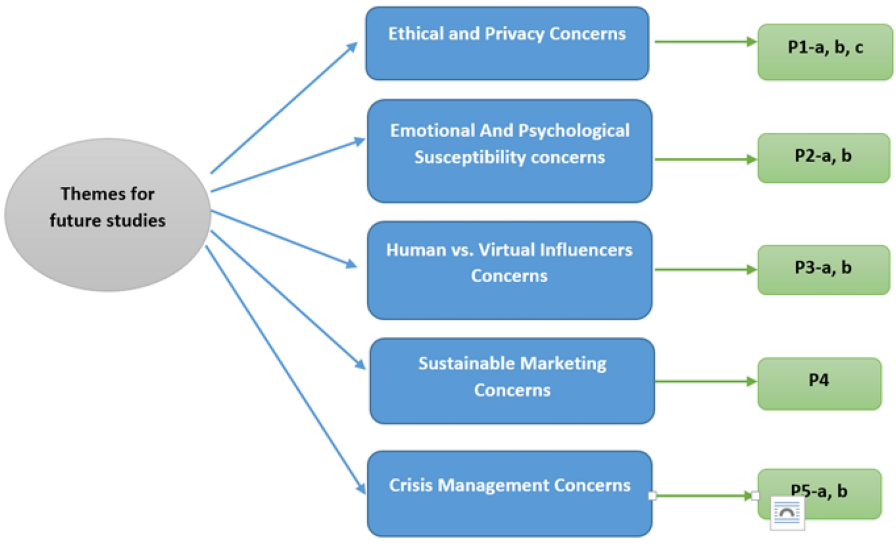


FIGURE 8
Future themes and propositions.

TABLE 10 Conceptual indicators for ethical and privacy concerns.

Conceptual indicators			
Antecedents	Mediators	Moderators	Outcomes
Trustworthiness	Sponsorship Disclosure	Data Privacy	Brand Loyalty
Authenticity		Ethical consumption values	Purchase Intention
Credibility			Purchase Decision

TABLE 11 Conceptual indicators for emotional and psychological susceptibility concerns.

Conceptual indicators			
Antecedents	Mediators	Moderators	Outcomes
Negative emotions – FOMO(fear of missing out), FOBO (fear of better options), Envy, Social anxiety, Paradox of choices	Emotional intensity	Interaction Quality	Willingness to buy
Positive Emotions-Empathy, Intimacy	Decision Paralysis		Unplanned purchase behaviour
			Emotional Response

TABLE 12 Conceptual indicators for human vs. virtual influencer concerns.

Conceptual indicators			
Antecedents	Mediators	Moderators	Outcomes
Influencer Attributes	Parasocial Interaction	Human vs. Virtual Influencers	Consumer Engagement
AR-induced Content Vividness	Self-concept alignment		Consumer Adoption
VIs narrative strategy	Emotional trust		

TABLE 13 Conceptual indicators for sustainable marketing concerns.

Conceptual indicators			
Antecedents	Mediators	Moderators	Outcomes
Perceived value	Brand consciousness	Environmental awareness	Purchase intention
	Sustainable promotion		Brand loyalty
	Desire to mimic	Gender	Unsustainable consumption

TABLE 14 Conceptual indicators for crisis management concerns.

Conceptual indicators			
Antecedents	Mediators	Moderators	Outcomes
Crises		Social advocacy	Consumer Engagement
e-WOM	Credibility		Brand detachment

Antecedents, Mediators, Moderators, and Outcomes to further enhance future studies in influencer marketing. The suggested framework categorises the antecedents into sub-factors, including influencer-related and brand and content-related factors. The mediators are also categorised as consumer and brand-related factors. The framework also provides an extensive list of moderators and outcomes that can serve as a foundation for future studies conducted in a more systematic manner. Further, the framework is elaborated and extensively provides variables and their relationships to be tested and analysed for different demographics, geographical and cultural settings.

5 Implications

Addressing the interplay between young consumers and influencer marketing has several theoretical implications. First, it follows a multidisciplinary approach that integrates influencer marketing with marketing, psychology, technology, and media communication, emphasising the need to delve deeper into this area in future research. Second, it advances our understanding of young consumer behaviour by underpinning a wide array of theories and communication frameworks, such as the Stimulus-Organism-Response (SOR) model, the Theory of Planned Behaviour, the Source Credibility theory, and the Parasocial Interaction (PSI) Theory. Third, the study helps identify significant attributes and influencer characteristics, such as perceived credibility, authenticity, similarity, persuasion knowledge, familiarity, and ethical dimensions that capture youth trust and subsequently affect their purchase decisions. Fourth, the nomological framework provides a strategic roadmap for future studies by categorising the antecedents, mediators, and moderators that generate the desired outcomes.

Alongside the theoretical implications, the study also provides actionable strategies for marketers, ranging from "reach-based" to "resonance-based" metrics. The study underscores the significance of brand partnerships with influencers and regulatory bodies in strengthening consumers' trust and fostering a positive social environment. It highlights that to achieve brand loyalty and successful marketing outcomes, popularity and attractiveness are not the sole drivers; rather, factors such as cultural sensitivity,

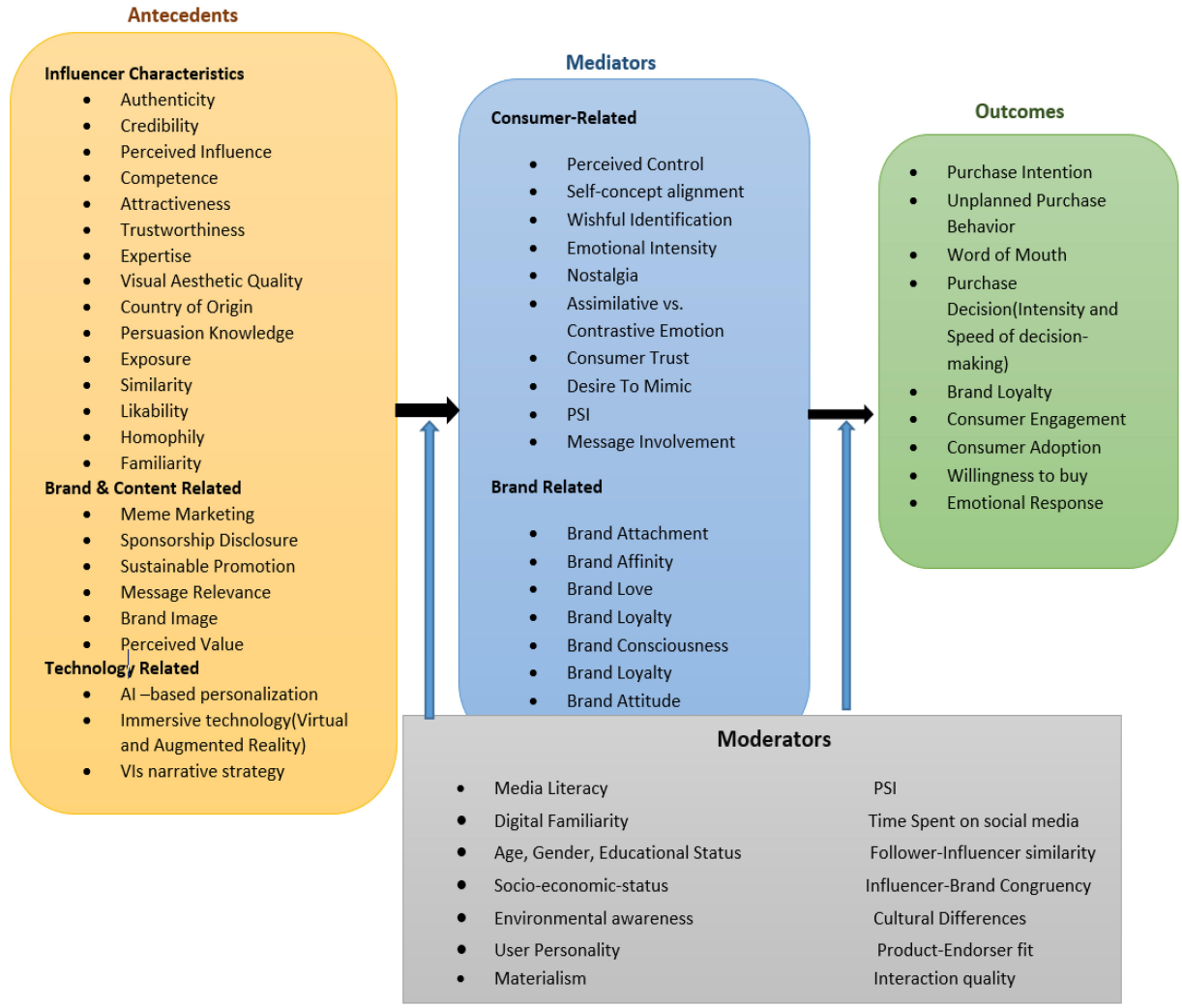


FIGURE 9
Author's own work.

transparency, authenticity, ethical alignment, and clear communication are key. Marketers should prioritise product-influencer congruency over "follower count" and stress effective monitoring, audits, and feedback on the content they develop, creating ethical standards that lead to desirable marketing outcomes.

5 Conclusion and limitations

The emergence of social media influencer (SMI) marketing has transformed the global marketing arena, shifting from traditional, one-way advertising toward a more interactive and immersive communication model. This systematic review focuses on a highly crucial generation cohort, i.e., Generation Z—the first generation of "digital natives"—that is identified as a dominant economic force. This review study is crucial, as it primarily targets young consumers' highly complex purchase behaviour and views SMI-led marketing as a tool to influence and dominate their decision-making (Alves de Castro and Sousa, 2025; De Veirman et al., 2017; Vrontis et al., 2021).

By synthesising 60 Scopus-indexed studies using the SPAR-4-SLR protocol and the TCCM framework, the review extends the "state-of-the-art" mapping of a fragmented field and offers a comprehensive understanding of the factors that affect youth trust, purchase behaviour, and their physical and mental well-being in relation to the IM phenomenon.

Despite its comprehensive nature, the study has many constraints. First, the findings are limited to the literature retrieved from the Scopus database using a well-defined search string, and any study outside the scope may be excluded. Future research should include other databases to cross-check and supplement the existing findings. Second, as influencer marketing is an emerging field, rapid advances may not be fully captured. To understand the complexities of influencer marketing, future studies should adopt more nuanced approaches that draw on empirical data and case studies. Third, the existing review is entirely focused

on the Generation Z cohort and young consumers. As a result, studies on influencer marketing that do not include this cohort may be exempt from review. Future research on other generational cohorts will reveal finer-grained insights.

Author contributions

PU: Methodology, Conceptualization, Data curation, Writing – original draft, Formal analysis, Writing – review & editing, Visualization. SB: Validation, Writing – review & editing, Supervision.

Funding

The author(s) declared that financial support was not received for this work and/or its publication.

Conflict of interest

The author(s) declared that this work was conducted in the absence of any commercial or financial relationships that could be construed as a potential conflict of interest.

Generative AI statement

The author(s) declared that generative AI was not used in the creation of this manuscript.

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Supplementary material

The Supplementary Material for this article can be found online at: https://www.frontiersin.org/articles/10.3389/fcomm.2026.1863261/full#supplementary-material

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